even though they broadly agreed with the prime minister's Iran policy. In January, when Israel and Hezbollah seemed close to a war, Herzog rushed before the cameras to announce his support for Netanyahu. "There is no coalition and no opposition," he declared.

Indeed, by the end of the debate, the audience had grown bored. Attendees started asking questions about gay marriage, the cost of living, the status of asylum-seekers from Africa—anything but security. The issue was raised only rarely during the final month of the campaign. In February, the heads of eight major political parties agreed to a two-and-a-half-hour televised debate on Channel 2. Netanyahu refused to participate, which compelled Herzog to withdraw, and the leader of the ultra-Orthodox United Torah Judaism also stayed away, presumably because his religious supporters are not meant to watch television. Still, the debate covered the full spectrum from right to left. And the word "peace" was mentioned exactly five times—three of them by Ayman Odeh, the leader of the Joint List, a coalition of parties representing Palestinian citizens of Israel.

"In this election, in this campaign, I think it's the first time that the word peace doesn't exist, in any party's slogan. No one talks about peace," said Ayelet Shaked, a prominent member of the right-wing Jewish Home party. "And I think that, in reality, most of the public acknowledges that we cannot make peace, even in the far future."

Fatigue

Sderot translates as "boulevards", but the city of 24,000 in southern Israel is better known for the bomb shelters that line the boulevards. It becomes a focal point for the media every few years when Israel goes to war against Hamas. The city sits just a few kilometers from the border with Gaza. More than 8,000 rockets have landed there over the past decade, according to the mayor.

In peacetime it is just another working-class locale on what Israelis call the periphery, the underdeveloped regions away from Jerusalem and the coastal plain. More than half of Sderot's residents live below the poverty line; salaries are well below the national average.

It is also a Likud stronghold. Among Sderot voters, 37 per cent opted for Likud in 2013, compared to 23 per cent nationwide. Like many towns in the Negev, it was built to absorb the waves of new immigrants—first *mizrahim*,